

This comes, I think, from their not believing the gods to have the same nature with men, as the Greeks imagine. Their wont, however, is to ascend the summits of the loftiest mountains, and there to offer sacrifice to Jupiter, which is the name they give to the whole circuit of the firmament. They likewise offer to the sun and moon, to the earth, to fire, to water, and to the winds. These are the only gods whose worship has come down to them from ancient times. At a later period they began the worship of Urania, which they borrowed³ from the Arabians and Assyrians. Mylitta is the name by which the Assyrians

³ The readiness of the Persians to adopt foreign customs, even in religion, is very remarkable. Perhaps the most striking instance is the adoption from the Assyrians of the well-known emblem figured below (Figs. 1, 2, 3), consisting of a winged circle, with or without a human figure rising from the circular space. This emblem is of Assyrian origin, appearing in the earliest sculptures of that country (Layard's *Nineveh*, vol. i. ch. v.). Its exact meaning is uncertain, but the conjecture is probable, that while in the human head we have the symbol of intelligence, the wings signify omnipresence, and the circle eternity. Thus the Persians were able, without the sacrifice of any principle, to admit it as a religious emblem, which we find them to have done, as early as the time of Darius, *universally* (see the sculptures at Persepolis, Nakhsh-i-Rustam, Behistun, &c.). It is quite a mistake to conclude from this, as Mr. Layard does (*Nineveh*, vol. ii. ch. vii.), that they adopted the Assyrian religion generally. The monuments prove the very contrary; for, with three exceptions, that of the symbol in question, that of the four-winged genius, and that of the colossal winged bulls, the Assyrian religious emblems do not re-appear in the early Persian sculptures.



Fig. 1.



Fig. 2.



Fig. 3.



Fig. 4.

A triple figure is sometimes found issuing from the circle (Fig. 4), which has been supposed to represent a triune god, but this mode of representation does not occur in the Persian sculptures. Some religious emblems seem to have been adopted by the Persians from the Egyptians; as, for instance, the curious head-dress of the four-winged genius at *Murg-aur* (Pasargadæ), which closely resembles a well-known Egyptian form. The Persian sculpture is of the time of Cyrus.